`Overcoming the limitations of software legacy

Court Case Management System

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PROBLEM DEFINITION

Current court information systems store case data in isolated and unstructured formats such as scanned PDFs, Excel sheets, or outdated databases. Each court typically maintains its own local repository, where case files are stored in non-searchable documents. As a result, searching for information, tracking case history, or analyzing workloads across courts is slow, inefficient, and prone to human error. Furthermore, in many cases, documentation and personal details of the involved parties must be manually transferred to higher institutions, where the entire case is rechecked and possibly re-entered into another system. This process significantly slows down legal procedures and contributes to the overall issue with unresolved cases.

In conclusion the problem is that court information systems are **fragmented** and rely on **unstructured**, **non-searchable data formats,** making case management, information sharing, and analysis **slow, inefficient, and error prone.** All of these can **lead to delays** in legal proceedings, **increased administrative workload**, and a **growing backlog** of unresolved cases, ultimately **reducing the overall effectiveness and transparency** of the justice system.

PROPOSED SOLUTION

The new modern system would store case information in a structured, searchable database, allowing courts to easily access, share, and update records in real time. By introducing standardized data formats, metadata extraction from uploaded documents, and automated synchronization between local and higher courts, the need for manual data transfer and rechecking would be eliminated.

In addition, the system could include intelligent search and filtering tools. **Intelligent search** will be implemented because of the inclusion of AI techniques (like machine learning and natural language processing) to understand the context, intent, and meaning behind queries. That being put together, will help to quickly locate related cases, track case progress, and generate analytical insights about workloads and resolution times.

REQUIREMENTS

The proposed Court Case Management System (CCMS) must **store all case data centrally** in a **structured, searchable format**, enabling authorized users across courts to **access, update, and share** records without manual duplication. It should support uploading documents and automatically extracting key metadata (case number, parties, dates, document type) to make files easily searchable. Users must have role-based access (judges, lawyers, administrators, citizens) and be able to track case progress through a clear timeline, with version control for all documents. The system should provide intelligent search and filtering by different categories/keywords, analytics for workloads and case durations, and safe data exchange between courts. The system should meet key non-functional requirements including security, reliability, performance and usability.

FUNCTIONAL REQUREMENTS

FR-1 Centralized structured case repository
The system shall store all case data centrally in a **structured, searchable database**, enabling authorized users across courts to access and update records without manual duplication.

FR-2 Authentication and role-based access control
The system shall authenticate users and enforce **role-based access** for (at minimum): judges, lawyers/attorneys, clerks, administrators, higher judicial authorities, and authorized public users.

FR-3 Case registration and party verification
The system shall allow clerks/administrative staff to register new cases, verify party details, and upload required documentation.

FR-4 Case lifecycle/state management
The system shall support case progression through states (including): **Draft, Filed, Under Review, Scheduled for Hearing, Deliberation, Judgment issued, Closed, Archived**, including transitions such as "return for correction", cancel, and appeal-related paths.

FR-5 Case status tracking with timeline
The system shall provide a detailed case view showing **current status** and a **case timeline/history** of updates (status changes, submissions, hearings).

FR-6 Lawyer self-service case tracking
The system shall let an authenticated lawyer view a list of their associated cases and track the status/history of a selected case, including filtering history by document type and/or date.

FR-7 Public portal case-status viewing
The system shall provide a public portal where an authorized public user can view limited case status/details using a **valid identifier (e.g., case number)**, and receive a generic error if the identifier is invalid or the case is not public.

FR-8 Public judgments access (where permitted)
The system shall allow authorized public users to access/download **publicly available final judgments** for cases flagged as public.

FR-9 Document upload and management
The system shall support uploading case documents, storing them in the repository, and associating them with the correct case record.

FR-10 Automatic metadata extraction
Upon document upload, the system shall automatically extract and store key metadata such as **case number, parties, dates, and document type** to make documents searchable.

FR-11 Document validation and compliance checks
When a lawyer submits documents, the system shall validate the submission for

format/correctness and handle invalid/incomplete documents appropriately (reject/return for correction).

FR-12 Version control + audit trail for changes
The system shall maintain a **version-controlled audit trail** for changes and documents (who changed what and when), supporting traceability across the case timeline.

FR-13 Access to approved documents
The system shall allow users (e.g., lawyers) to access/view/download **approved files** linked in the case timeline, after verifying permissions.

FR-14 Review workflow and remarks/notes
The system shall enable judges/authorized reviewers to review case files and evidence, provide remarks/notes, approve/forward files, or return files for correction when submissions are incomplete/incorrect.

FR-15 Intelligent search and filtering
The system shall provide search and filtering across cases/documents by categories/keywords, including **intelligent search** (AI techniques like ML/NLP) to improve retrieval and context-based matching.

FR-16 Tagging and linking related cases
The system shall allow staff to add internal tags and link related cases to improve organization and retrieval.

FR-17 Analytics and workload monitoring
The system shall provide analytics/reporting for higher judicial authorities including metrics such as **active cases per judge, resolution times, pending vs. closed cases**, with filtering by division/judge/case type.

FR-18 Case reassignment for workload balancing
The system shall allow higher judicial authorities to reassign cases to other courts/judges, logging the action and notifying relevant parties.

FR-19 Transfer of case files to higher courts
The system shall support transferring complete case files to higher courts (e.g., appellate), including verifying documentation consistency before transfer, synchronizing case data and associated documents, updating status to "Transferred", and notifying both sides.

FR-20 Calendar/hearing schedule management
The system shall provide a calendar view for managing/overviewing **legal meetings and court proceedings** (hearings schedule visibility).

FR-21 Contacts directory
The system shall provide a contacts section (directory of judges, attorneys, court staff), searchable and viewable by authorized users.

FR-22 Dashboard overview
The system shall provide a dashboard summarizing case statistics (e.g., active/pending/upcoming hearings/closed) and lists such as recent cases and upcoming hearings.

NON-FUNCTIONAL REQUREMENTS

NFR-1 Security (access control + privacy)
The system shall enforce strict role-based permissions, ensuring that users only see data allowed by their role; the public view must never expose personal/confidential details.

NFR-2 Secure data exchange between courts
Case transfers and synchronization between local and higher courts shall use secure, standardized exchange mechanisms aligned with security requirements.

NFR-3 Integrity and auditability
The system shall preserve data integrity and provide audit logs/version control so that all changes are traceable and cannot be silently altered.

NFR-4 Reliability and consistency
The system shall reliably maintain consistent case records across courts, including reliable synchronization so that transferred cases include all required metadata and document links.

NFR-5 Performance (search + retrieval + "real-time" access)
The system shall provide responsive access to case records and support efficient searching/filtering and timely updates for authorized users across courts.

NFR-6 Usability
The system shall be easy to use for different stakeholders, including clear presentation of case progress via a timeline, and intuitive UI sections (Dashboard, Cases, Documents, Calendar, Contacts).

NFR-7 Transparency (controlled)
The system shall improve transparency by offering self-service status checking and public judgments **only** where the case is flagged as publicly available, without increasing staff workload.

NFR-8 Maintainability and extensibility
The system shall be designed so new report types, new document types/metadata fields, and additional court levels can be added without breaking existing functionality (important for replacing fragmented legacy systems).

USER STORY

The CCMS is designed to digitalize and streamline judicial processes by enabling efficient handling of case files, documents, and communications among different court stakeholders. The system provides distinct functionalities for judges, lawyers, court clerks, administrative staff, and authorized public users.

Judges and higher judicial authorities can review case files, examine evidence, provide remarks, and update case progress after verifying all relevant information. They can also attach supporting notes, return files for correction, or reassign cases in instances of jurisdictional change. Lawyers are able to submit case-related documents electronically, monitor case status, view hearing schedules, and access approved files, ensuring that all submissions comply with the required format and standards.

Court clerks and administrative staff are responsible for registering new cases, verifying party details, uploading necessary documentation, and forwarding files to higher courts when required. They may also assign internal tags and link related cases to facilitate efficient case management and retrieval.

Authorized public users can access limited system features, such as viewing case statuses and publicly available judgments through valid case identifiers, with the option to download permitted documents for reference.

Overall, the CCMS enhances transparency, efficiency, and accessibility within the judicial process by providing a secure, centralized digital platform for managing all stages of court proceedings.
On the following page, Figure 1: UML Use Case Diagram you have a full representation of all the use cases a user(s) can have whilst using this court system.

USE CASE DESCRIPTIONS

Use Case Name: Submitting case documents

Actors:

- Primary actor: Lawyer
- Supporting actor: Court clerk

Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- The Lawyer is authenticated and has authorized access to the Court Case Management
- System (CCMS).
- The case to which the documents belong is already registered and active in the system
- The required documents (e.g., petitions, evidence, motions) are available in the correct
- digital format (PDF, DOCX, etc.).

Trigger:

The Lawyer selects the option **"Submit Case Documents"** from the CCMS dashboard to upload case-related files for an existing case.

Main Flow:

1. The Lawyer logs into the CCMS.
2. The Lawyer selects **"Submit Case Documents."**
3. The system displays a list of cases associated with the Lawyer.
4. The Lawyer selects the desired case.
5. The system shows a list of required or optional document types (e.g., "Evidence," "Witness Statement," "Petition").
6. The Lawyer uploads the relevant files for each document type.
7. The system verifies document type, size, and format compliance.
8. The Lawyer provides any additional information or remarks (e.g., date filed, exhibit number).
9. The Lawyer confirms submission.
10. The system stores the uploaded documents, links them to the selected case, and updates the case-record.
11. A confirmation message is displayed, and notifications are sent to the assigned Court Clerk and Judge.

Post-Conditions:

- The submitted documents are successfully uploaded, validated, and stored in the system.
- The case record is updated with new documents.
- Relevant stakeholders (e.g., Clerk, Judge) are notified of the submission.

Alternative path:

Description: The Lawyer uploads a document that doesn't meet system format requirements.

1. During step 7 of the main flow, the system detects that one or more files are in an unsupported format (e.g., .jpg instead of .pdf).
2. The system displays an error message indicating the invalid format.
3. The Lawyer removes the invalid file and uploads a corrected version.
4. Once all documents are valid, the Lawyer continues with step 8 of the main flow (confirm submission).

Outcome: The document submission succeeds after all files are in the correct format.

Other:

- **Frequency of Use:** Moderate (several times per day).
- **Business Rules:**
  - Only authorized lawyers assigned to the case can upload documents.
  - All documents must be in approved formats and properly signed.
  - Each submission is logged with a timestamp for audit purposes.
- **Assumptions:**
  - The system is online and the database is functioning.
  - Notification services (email/internal) are also functioning.

Use Case Name: Register new case

Actors:

- Primary: Clerk/Administrator
- Secondary: None

Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- The Clerk/Administrator is authenticated and has authorization to register new cases in the Court Case Management System (CCMS).
- The necessary case details (case type, parties involved, court division) are available.
- The system's case registration and database modules are functioning properly.

Trigger:

The Clerk/Administrator selects the **"Register New Case"** option from the CCMS

Main Flow:

1. The Clerk logs into the CCMS.
2. From the main dashboard, the Clerk selects **"Register New Case."**
3. The system displays the case registration form.
4. The Clerk enters the required details, including:
   a. Case title and reference number.
   b. Names of involved parties (plaintiff, defendant, attorney).
   c. Type of case and assigned court division.

5. The Clerk verifies entered data for accuracy and completeness.
6. The system automatically checks for duplicate records and validates data format.
7. The Clerk submits the registration form.
8. The system assigns a unique case ID and confirms successful registration.
9. The system notifies the relevant judge and administrative users of the new case entry.

Post-Conditions:

- The case is successfully created and stored in the CCMS database.
- The case receives a unique ID and appears in the "Active Cases" list.
- Notifications are sent to relevant court staff and assigned personnel.

Alternative Path(s):

A1: Missing or Invalid Case Data

1. During step 5, if required information is missing or invalid, the system displays an error message.
2. The Clerk corrects the invalid fields or completes missing data.
3. Once all fields are validated, the main flow resumes from step 7.

A2: Duplicate Case Detected

1. During step 6, if the system detects an existing case with identical identifiers, it alerts the Clerk.
2. The Clerk may either confirm it as a new, related case or cancel the registration.
3. If confirmed as related, the Clerk tags it using the **"Assign Tags or Links for Related Cases"** function.

Other:

- Frequency of Use: Moderate – new cases are registered several times daily by clerks.
- Business Rules:
    - Each new case must have a unique identifier and verified party details.
    - Only authorized clerks may perform case registrations.
    - All registration activities must be timestamped and recorded in the audit log.

Assumptions:

1. The database connection and validation scripts function correctly.
2. Notification services for judges and court divisions are operational.
3. The Clerk follows internal naming and formatting standards when entering case data.

Use Case Name: Track case status

Actors:

- Primary actor: Lawyer/Attorney

Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- This use case fulfills the requirement to provide authorized legal professionals with real-time, self-service access to the current status and detailed history of their active cases.
- Its goal is to enhance transparency and efficiency for lawyers, thereby reducing administrative workload and speeding up legal procedures.
- **Conditions:** The Lawyer must be authenticated, and the case data must be present in the structured database.

Trigger:

- The Lawyer selects the "Track Case Status" option from their CCMS dashboard to check on one of their active cases.

Main Flow:

1. The Lawyer logs into the CCMS.
2. The Lawyer selects "Track Case Status".
3. The system displays a list of cases associated with the Lawyer.
4. The Lawyer selects the desired case.
5. The system displays the detailed case view, showing the current status and a case timeline.
6. The Lawyer reviews the timeline for the most recent updates (e.g., status changes, submissions, hearings).
7. The Lawyer can filter the history by document type or date if needed.
8. The Lawyer concludes the review.

Post-Conditions:

- The Lawyer successfully reviewed the case's current status and history.
- The case status remains unchanged.

Alternative path:

Description: The Lawyer decides to view documents related to the current status update.

1. During step 6 of the main flow, the Lawyer sees a document linked in the timeline.
2. The Lawyer selects the option to Access Approved Files.
3. The system verifies the Lawyer's access permissions for the specific document.
4. The system presents the approved document for viewing or offers a download option.
5. The Lawyer returns to the case status page.

Outcome: The Lawyer successfully views an approved document with- out leaving the case track page.

Other:

- Frequency of Use: High (multiple times per day).
- Business Rules:
    - Lawyers can only track cases they are actively associated with.
    - The system must maintain a version-controlled audit trail for all changes.

Use Case Name: Monitor court workloads

Actors:

- Primary actor: Higher Judicial Authorities

Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- This use case fulfills the core requirement to provide analytical in- sights and a clear overview of judicial workloads, case distribution, and resolution times.
- Its goal is to enable Higher Judicial Authorities to make data-driven administrative decisions, identify resource imbalances and bottlenecks, and ultimately improve system efficiency and reduce the growing backlog of unresolved cases.
- **Conditions:** The Authority must have administrative access, and all case data must be current and correctly assigned in the structured database.

Trigger:

A Higher Judicial Authority selects the option to "Monitor Court Work- loads" from their administrative dashboard to assess judicial resource allocation and efficiency.

Main Flow:

1. The Authority logs into the CCMS.
2. The Authority navigates to the Analytics or Reporting section.
3. The Authority selects the Monitor Court Workloads option.
4. The system presents an analytical report, showing metrics like active cases per judge, resolution times, and pending vs. closed cases.
5. The Authority applies filters (e.g., by court division, judge, or case type).
6. The Authority identifies courts or judges with workload imbalances or bottlenecks.
7. The Authority may then proceed to Reassign Cases to Other Courts.
8. The Authority exits the monitoring tool.

Post-Conditions:

- The Authority successfully generated analytical insights about work- loads and resolution times.
- The information is used for administrative decision-making to optimize court performance.

Alternative path (Reassign Cases to Other Courts):

Description: The Authority identifies a court or judge with an excessive backlog requiring reallocation.

- Following step 6 of the main flow, the Authority selects the
- Reassign Cases to Other Courts option.
- The Authority selects the cases to be transferred.
- The Authority specifies the receiving court or judge.
- The system logs the re-assignment action and updates the case records.
- Notifications are sent to all relevant parties.
- **Outcome:** The case assignment is updated, and the workload is redistributed.

Other:

- Frequency of Use: Moderate (used for strategic planning and resource management).
- Business Rules:
    - All workload data must be current and reliable for accurate analysis.
    - The system must prevent unauthorized changes to case assignments.

Use Case Name: Transfer case files to higher courts

Actors:

- Primary actor: Clerks/Administrator
- Supporting actor: Higher Judicial Authorities

Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- This use case fulfills the critical requirement to automatically and securely transfer complete, structured case files to higher institutions (like appellate courts).
- Its goal is to eliminate the need for manual transfer and re-entry of data, which significantly reduces human error and speeds up legal procedures by ensuring data consistency across judicial levels.
- **Conditions:** The case file must be complete and digitally compliant, and the system must support secure, standardized data exchange.

Trigger:

A Clerk/Administrator receives an instruction or determines via case status that a file must be forwarded to a higher court (e.g., an appeal is granted).

Main Flow:

1. The Clerk logs into the CCMS.
2. The Clerk selects the case file to be transferred.
3. The Clerk selects the Transfer Case Files to Higher Courts option.
4. The system performs Verify Documentation Consistency to ensure all necessary documents are present.
5. The Clerk specifies the target Higher Court/Authority.
6. The system initiates the secure data exchange and automated synchronization of the case file and associated documents.
7. The system updates the case status to “Transferred” and logs the action.
8. The system sends a notification to the target Higher Judicial Authority and the originating court.
9. A confirmation message is displayed to the Clerk.

Post-Conditions:

- The case file and data are securely and automatically transferred and synchronized.
- The case record is updated with the new status, eliminating the need for manual rechecking.

Alternative path (Verification Failure):
Description: The system detects that required documents are missing or noncompliant before transfer.

1. During step 4 of the main flow, the system returns a failure from Verify Documentation Consistency.
2. The system displays an error message detailing the missing or noncompliant documents.
3. The Clerk uploads the missing documentation or corrects the files.
4. Once compliant, the main flow resumes from step 6.

Outcome: The file transfer is delayed until documentation integrity is ensured.
Other:

- Frequency of Use: Moderate.
- Business Rules:
  - The transfer protocol must adhere to non- functional requirements for security and reliability.
  - Synchronization must include all case metadata and links to the submitted documents.

Use Case Name: Evaluate case file

Actor(s): Judge
Requirements / Pre-Conditions:

- The Judge is **authenticated** and has **authorized access** to the CCMS.
- The system has **assigned the case** to the Judge.
- The case file is **complete** (or ready for review) and has been **forwarded** to the Judge's queue.
- The Judge has the **necessary permissions** to access and modify the case status.

Trigger:
The Judge selects an assigned case from their personal dashboard to **begin review**.
Main Flow:

1. The Judge logs into the CCMS.
2. The Judge accesses their assigned case list or dashboard.
3. The Judge selects the desired case file for evaluation.
4. The system displays the **structured case file**, including all documents, submission history, party details, and a case timeline.
5. The Judge reviews the submitted documents and evidence, possibly using the system's **intelligent search/filtering** tools for cross referencing.
6. The Judge adds **internal notes or remarks** to the case file for their own records or for higher judicial authorities.
7. The Judge determines if the file is **complete and correct** for further proceedings (e.g., scheduling a hearing or issuing a ruling).
8. The Judge selects the option to **update the case progress** (e.g., "Ready for Hearing," "Under Review," or "Ruling Issued").

9. The system updates the case status, logs the action with a timestamp, and stores any attached notes.
10. The system displays a **confirmation** of the status update.

6. Post-Conditions:

- The Judge's evaluation remarks (if any) are attached to the case file.
- The case progress/status is **updated** in the system.
- Relevant stakeholders (e.g., Lawyers, Court Clerk) are **notified** of the case status change.

7. Alternative Path (Return File for Correction)**:**

(Occurs after Step 7 of the Main Flow)

Description: The Judge finds **errors, missing documents, or noncompliant submissions** that require rectification by a Clerk or Lawyer before proceeding.

1. Instead of updating the progress, the Judge selects the **"Return for Correction"** option.
2. The Judge provides a **mandatory explanation** outlining the reasons for the return (e.g., "Missing Exhibit A, "Format non-compliant, "Requires clarification on Motion X").
3. The Judge specifies the **stakeholder** responsible for the correction (e.g., Lawyer, Court Clerk).
4. The Judge confirms the return.
5. The system **reverts the case status** (e.g., to "Correction Required" or "Returned to Clerk/Lawyer"), links the Judge's explanation to the file, and logs the action.
6. A **notification** is automatically sent to the specified responsible stakeholder with the instructions for correction.
7. The Judge concludes the interaction with this case file.

Outcome: The case file is returned to the appropriate party, and the case status clearly indicates that **further action/correction is required** before the Judge can proceed with the evaluation.

Other:

- Frequency of Use: High (multiple times per day).
- Business Rules:
    - The Judge must provide **digital signature/authentication** for all case status updates that affect the judicial timeline.
    - Any modification to the case status or progress must adhere tothe **prescribed judicial workflow**.
    - The system must maintain a **version-controlled audit trail** for every note, remark, or status change made by the Judge.

Assumptions:

1. The system's **role-based access control** ensures the Judge only sees cases assigned to them.
2. The searchable**, structured data** proposed in the solution is available to facilitate quick review and retrieval of related information.

UML DIAGRAMS

1. UML Use Case Diagram

Description

The Use Case Diagram represents the functional scope of the (CCMS) and the interactions between the system and its users. The primary actors include
judges, lawyers, court clerks, higher judicial authorities, and authorized public users. Each actor interacts with the system according to their role, performing actions such as submitting documents, viewing case files, scheduling hearings, and accessing approved files. The diagram highlights all the most important use cases (like submitting documents, tracking the status of the case, reviewing the case files, providing remarks, schedule hearings etc.). By modeling these interactions, the diagram helps stakeholders understand user goals and system functionality at a glance.

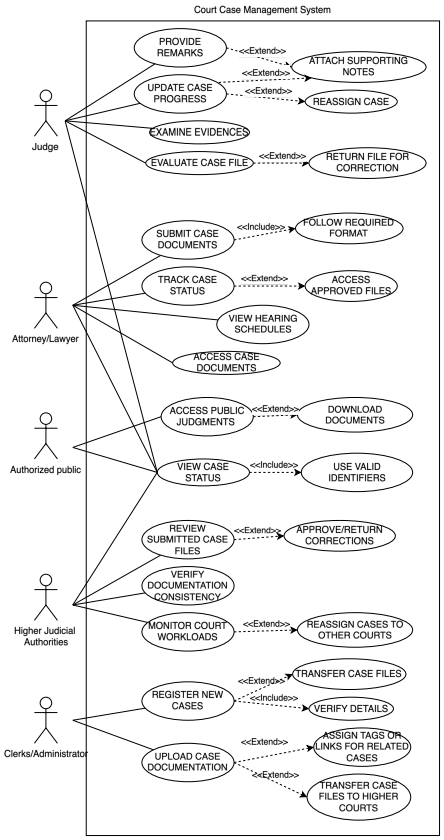


Figure 1: UML Use Case Diagram

2. UML State Diagram

Description

The State Diagram models the lifecycle of a court case within the CCMS. A case progresses through multiple states, including “Draft”, “Filed”, “Under review”, “Scheduled for Hearing”, “deliberation”, “Judgment issued”, “Closed,” and “Archived.” Transitions between states occur as a result of events such as document submission, judge review, hearing scheduling, and case closure. Alternative paths, like returning a case for correction, or canceling a case or potentially appealing the process, are also included to reflect real-world variations. This diagram provides a clear understanding of the different stages a case can go through and how the system responds to changes in status.

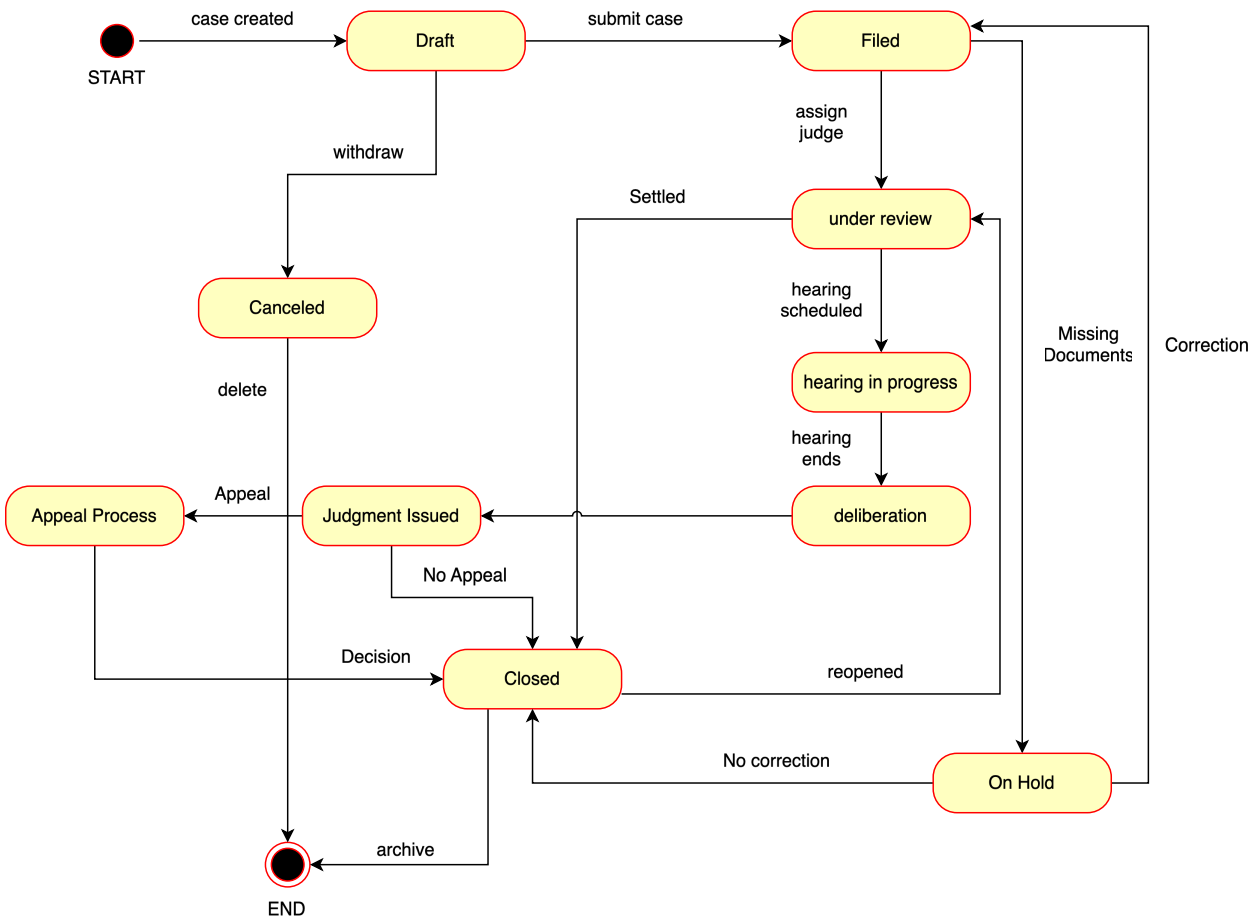


Figure 2: UML State Diagram

3. UML Activity Diagram

Description
The Activity Diagram shows the workflow for reviewing submitted case files in the CCMS. A judge or authorized reviewer selects a case, examines the documents and evidence, and checks whether files need to be corrected or not. Based on the review, the case can be approved and forwarded to the judge or returned for correction. Decision points represent alternative paths for incomplete or incorrect submissions. The diagram clarifies the sequence of actions and possible outcomes during the review process.

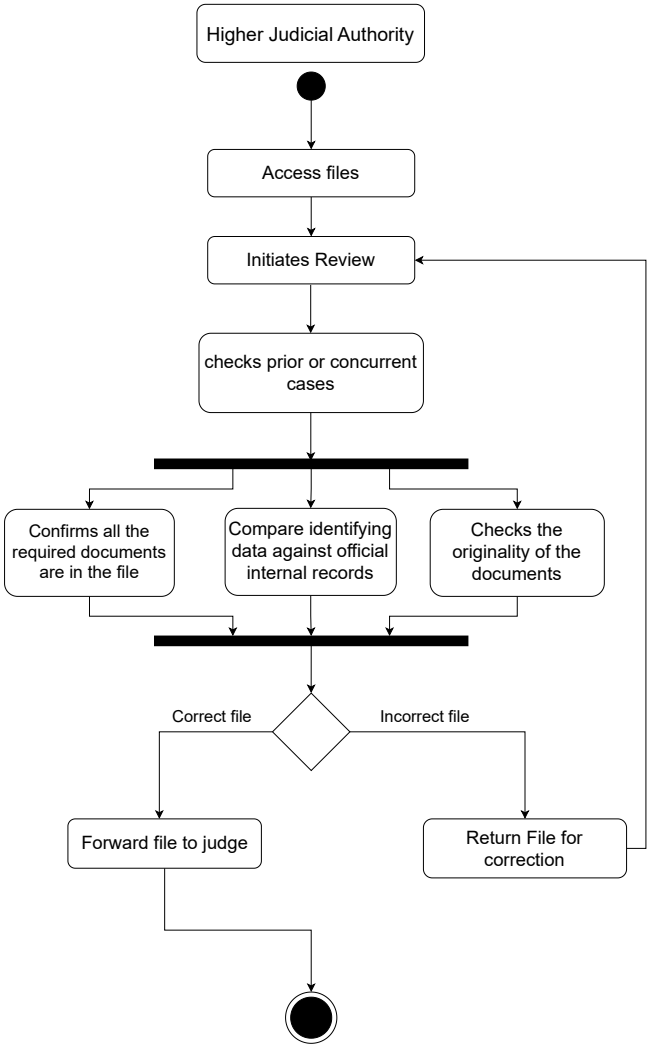


Figure 3: Activity Diagram

4. UML Sequence Diagram

Description

The Sequence Diagram depicts the interaction between a lawyer, the CCMS, and the database when submitting a document. It shows the chronological flow of messages, starting from choosing an option in the application, selection of the case, checking and selecting document type, document upload, and server-side validation regarding the format and correctness. Once the document is verified, the system sends it to the database for storage and returns a confirmation tothe user. Alternative flows, such as handling invalid or incomplete documents, can also be represented. This diagram clarifies the sequence of operations and the roles of different objects in processing a user request. It is useful for de

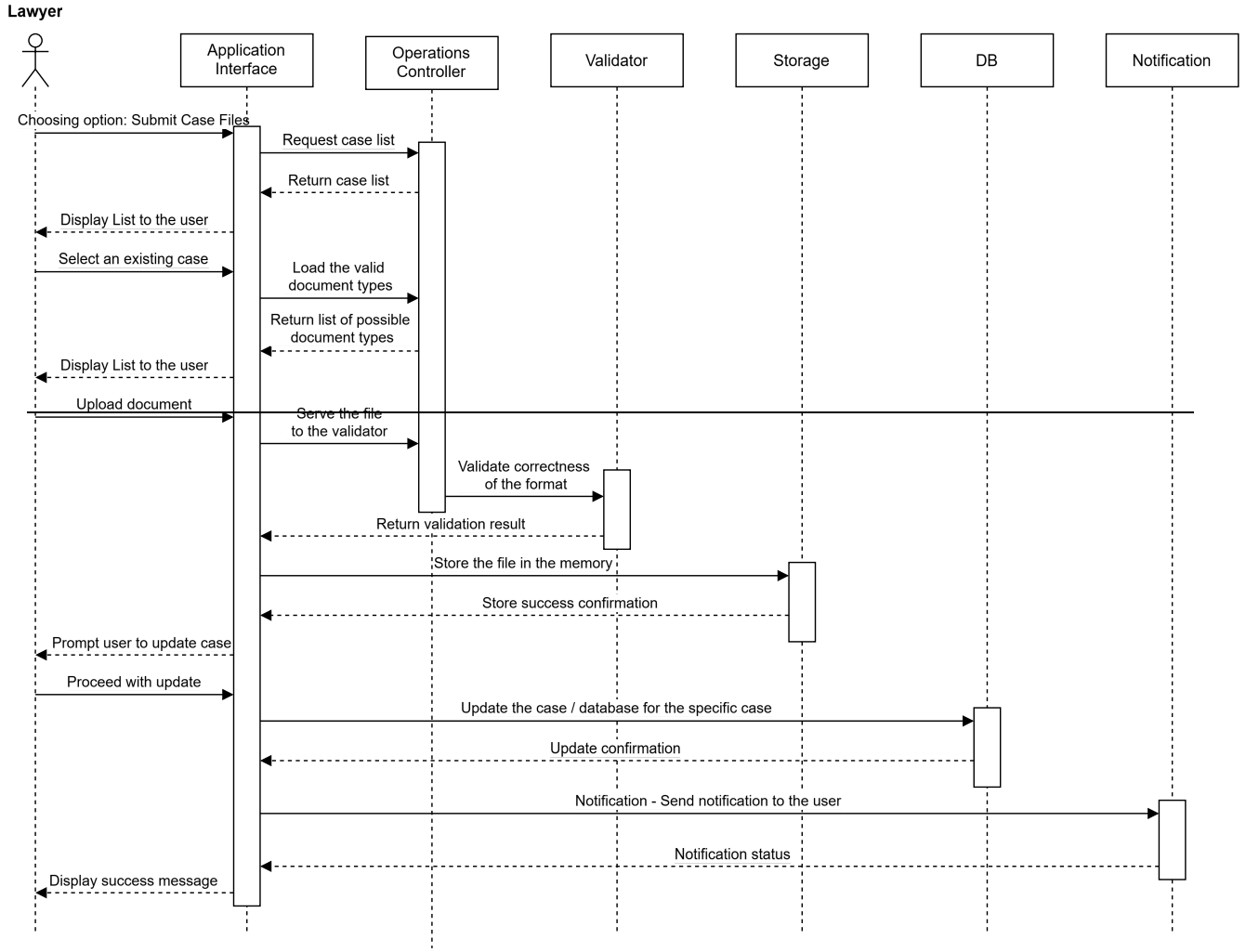
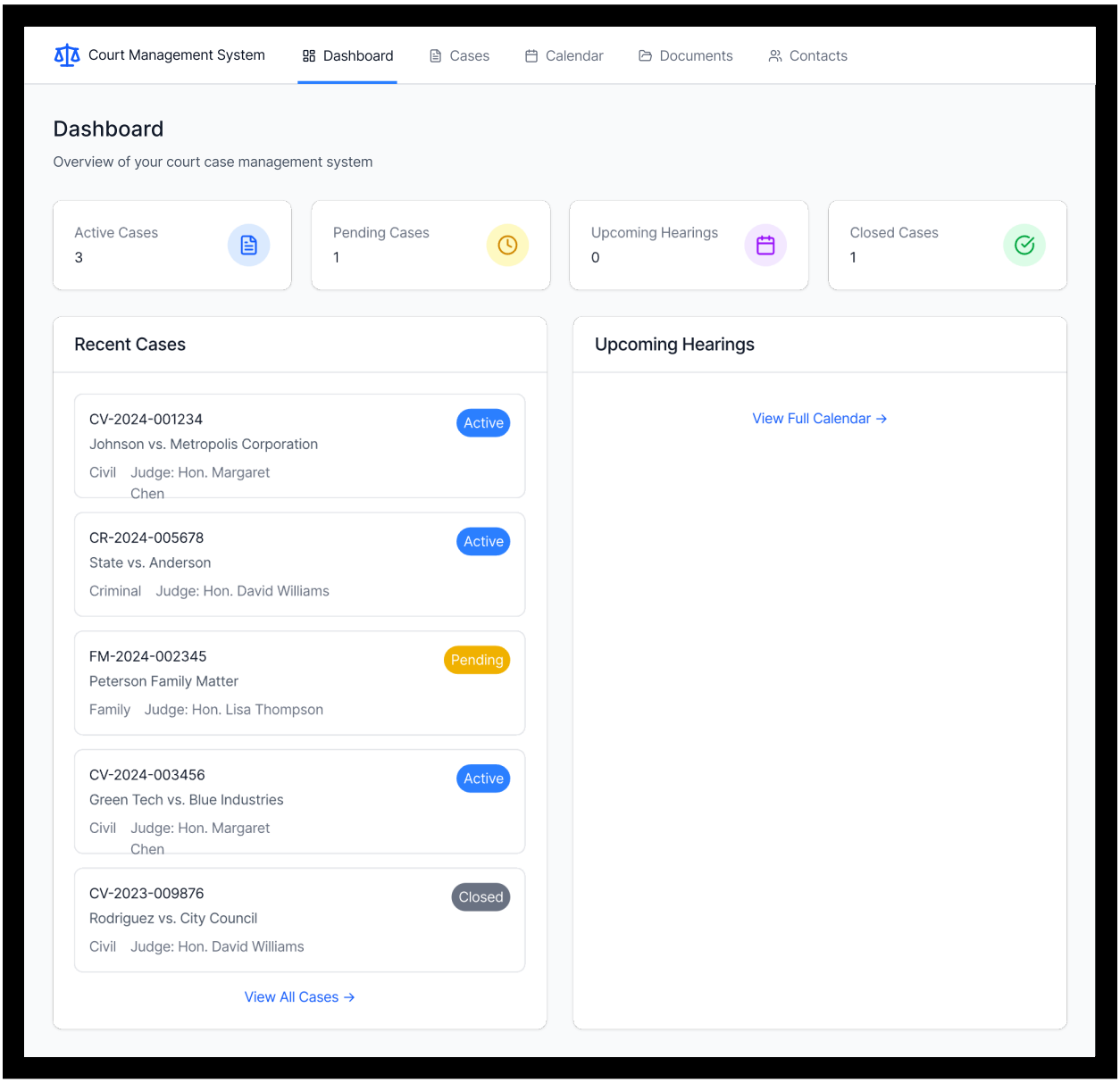


Figure 4: Sequence Diagram

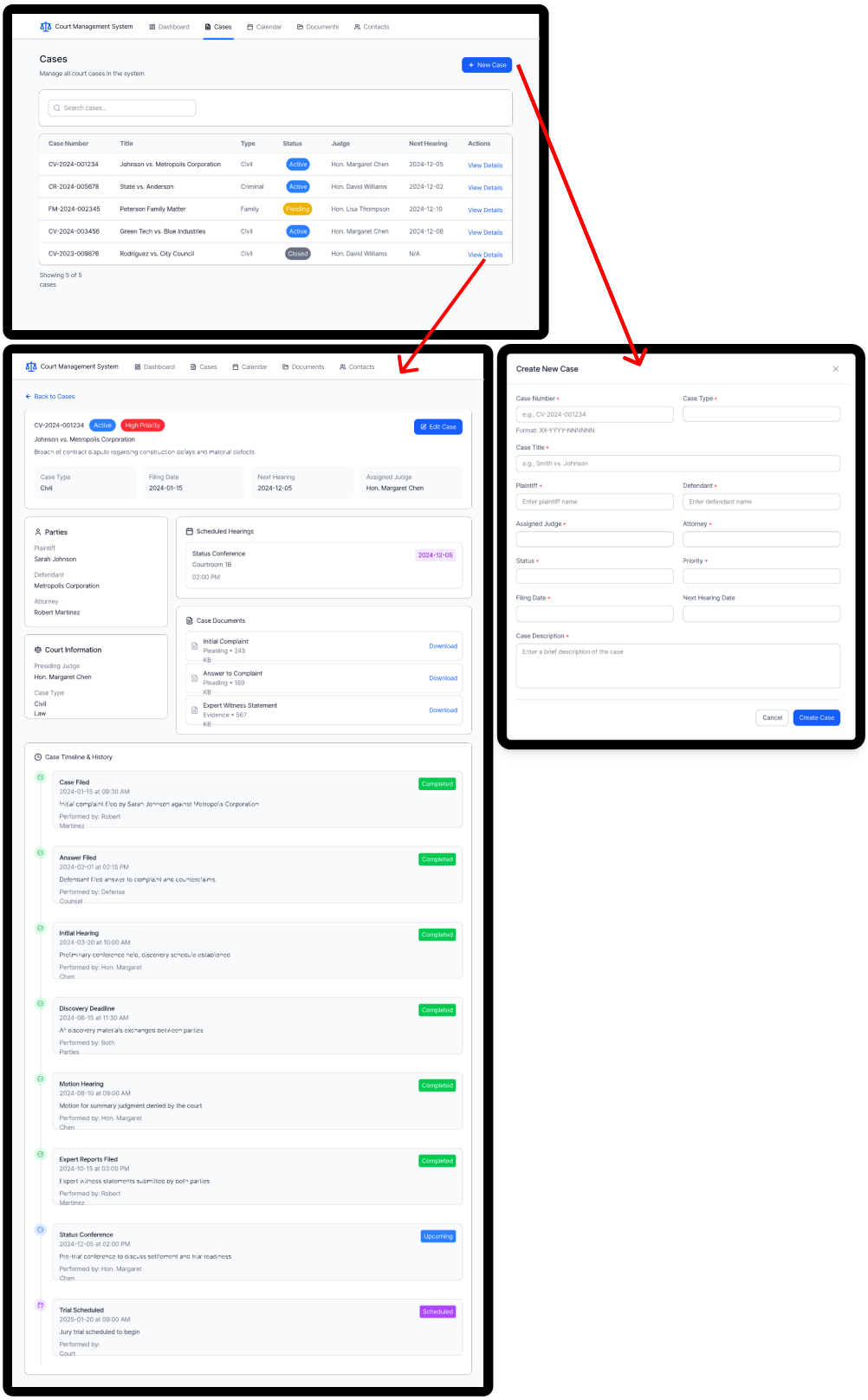
USER INTERFACE MOCKUPS

Home Dashboard



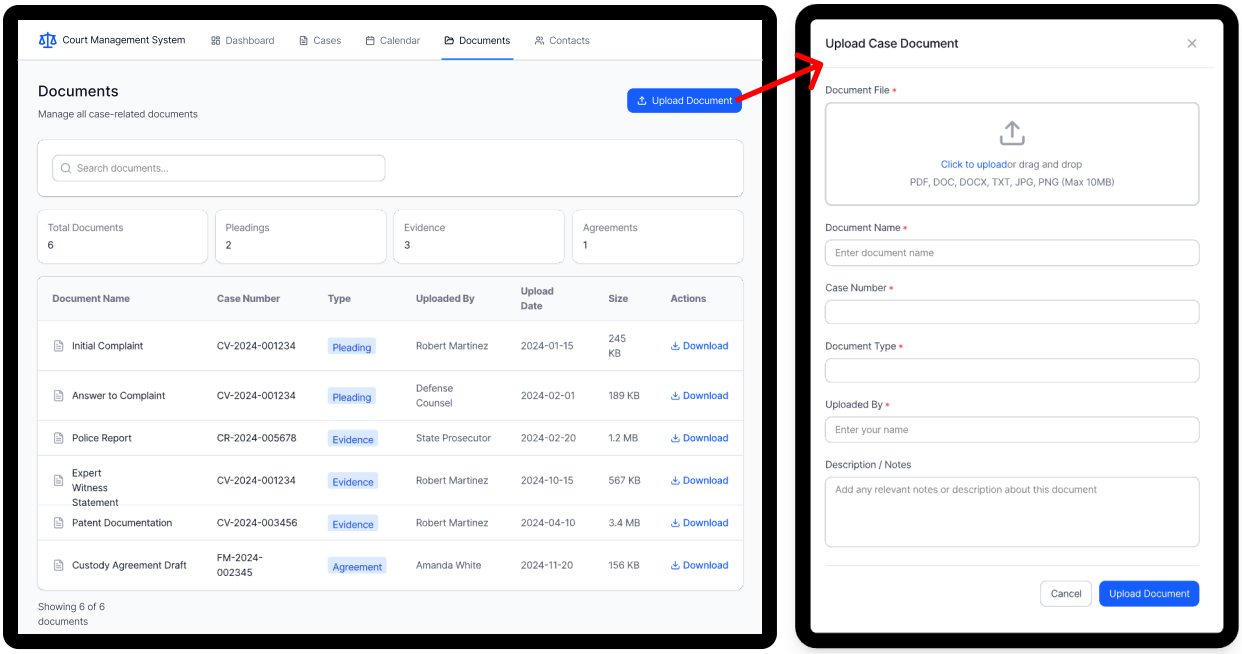
Mockup Screen 1: Dashboard

Cases Page (management of cases)



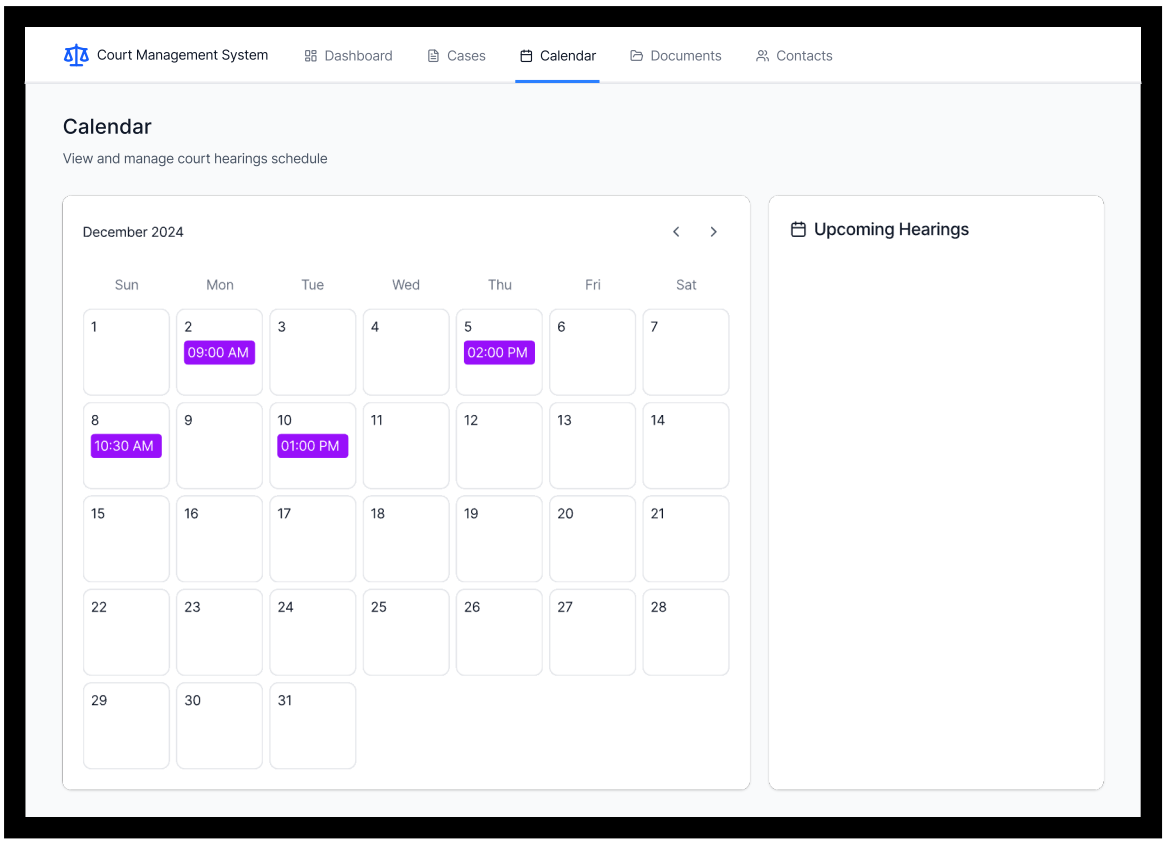
Mockup Screen 2: Case

Documents Page (management of case documents)



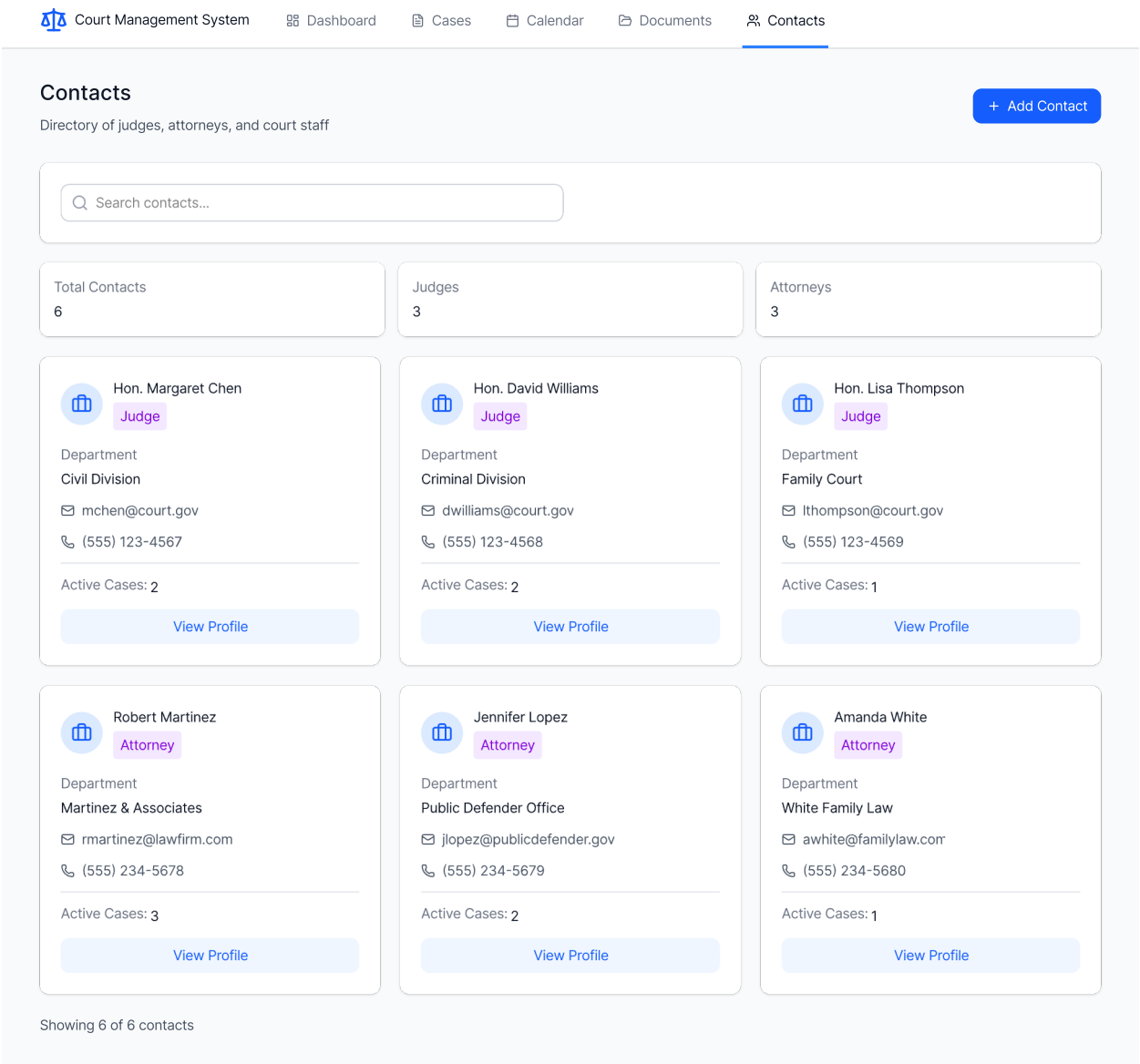
Mockup Screen 3: Documents

Calendar Tab (Overview of legal meetings and court proceedings)



Mockup Screen 4: Calendar

Contacts Page



Mockup Screen 5: Contacts